INDIA@PARIS 2024

HOPING TO MAKE A SPLASH

SRIHARI NATARAJ, 23

Sport: *SWIMMING* *Men's 100m Backstroke*

Achievement: **Broke three national records, including the 200m freestyle mark, at the Asian Games in Hangzhou last year**

How he qualified: **Through the Universality quota that is handed out to National Olympic Committees when they don't have any qualified athletes or relay teams**

Through most of June 23, Srihari Nataraj had one eye glued to a computer screen. Over in Canada, another Indian swimmer, Aryan Nehra, was participating at the Mel Zajac Jr International. By the end of it, Aryan had clinched two silver medals, but failed to collect adequate points to get past Srihari's tally of the Olympic qualification cycle from March 2023 to June 2024. Two days later, Srihari had the confirmation that he was going to his second consecutive Olympic Games.

The Bengaluru athlete's best swim came at the Asian Games in Hangzhou, China, last September, where he lost out on a medal in the 100-metre backstroke final by a few milliseconds. More significantly, he got within touching distance of the Olympic qualification timing, missing it by an even smaller margin. Yet, there were a lot of positives he returned home with. "It's not the first time I got so close to a medal—it happened at the World Junior Championships in 2019 and then the Commonwealth Games in 2022. The Asian Games taught me to manage myself better amid a busy schedule," he



SELVAPRAKASH LAKSHMANAN